



Relentless: Novak Djokovic managed to reach yet another semifinal, only to be stopped by Alcaraz. AFP

McEnroe. The moral: never change a winning game. An energised Sinner held serve and broke Alcaraz's serve at love in the next game for a 3-1 lead. After Sinner grabbed the set 6-3, John McEnroe said, "Alcaraz had let him off the hook early, and Sinner got back on track." The telling stat: Carlitos had no forehand winners in the second set.

Alcaraz learned his lesson and quickly re-established his power game and momentum in the pivotal third set. Notching two service breaks, he raced to a 5-0 lead and took the set 6-1.

Although Sinner had never beaten Alcaraz in a five-set match, the Spaniard went all-out to close out the

final in four sets. The Italian, sensing defeat was near, started hitting harder and closer to the lines. That backfired when Sinner committed two unforced forehand errors and a double fault to lose his serve and give Alcaraz a 3-2 lead.

Sinner ran out of time and answers. The crowd roared during the changeover at 5-4 Alcaraz. But a fifth set was not to be. At 40-all, Alcaraz whacked an overhead winner and smiled. Then, on his third championship point, he fired an ace to prevail.

During the trophy presentation, Alcaraz looked at Sinner and quipped, "I'm seeing you more than my family."

Always gracious in victory or defeat, he said, "I think physically he has improved a lot. He has spoken about the physical conditions that he had to improve, and I think in the last

year or two, he has improved a lot. His matches are really demanding physically, that he's able to play at 100 per cent during two, three, four hours. I think that's the biggest improvement he has made."

The gulf between Sincaraz and the rest of the field is large and seemingly growing. Djokovic, in the late twilight of his glorious career, still managed to reach the semifinals at every Major this season, defeating No. 4 Taylor Fritz, the 2024 finalist here, 6-3, 7-5, 3-6, 6-4.

Auger-Aliassime, a mild-mannered, 25-year-old Canadian with a big serve and dangerous forehand, upset three veteran contenders with different playing styles — No. 3 Alexander Zverev, No. 15 Andrey Rublev, and No. 8 Alex de Minaur.

What about world No. 10 Lorenzo Musetti? After Sinner, his compatriot and friend, overpowered him 6-1, 6-4, 6-2 in the quarterfinals, he acknowledged, "I never played someone who put me in this kind of rush in the rally. I didn't have many chances in the rally, and he was always leading the rally."

Holger Rune, the gifted but at-times immature Dane who reached a career-high No. 4 two years ago, lost to 35-year-old journeyman Jan-Lennard Struff. Ben Shelton, playing his first Major as a top 10 player, was forced to retire after splitting four sets with an injured shoulder against 37-year-old Adrian Mannarino. "It was the worst pain I've ever felt in my life," said the American. Joao Fonseca, a highly touted 19-year-old Brazilian who regularly hammers forehands over 100 mph, was ousted in straight sets by 21st-seeded Tomas Machac. No. 5 Jack Draper, a heavy-hitting lefty, part-time model, and British heartthrob, had to default in the second round due to a left arm injury.

Mary Joe Fernandez predicts the Sincaraz rivalry "is going to keep going back and forth, and they're going to make each other better."

Sinner said he'll reach his peak in four years at age 28. How much better can this superstar get?

Alcaraz doesn't appear worried. "I